

with the bike messenger who shopped compulsively on the Internet. I chatted with the actress who came to DA with \$120,000 in credit card debt spent on cars and vacations, because every time she got a card, she spent to the limit, as if it were her own money. These weren't people who "didn't stick to a budget." Their spending and debt signified chronic problems that require long-term treatment and close work with a DA sponsor, someone who has broken free of the financial quagmire and is willing to help others out.

I was fascinated by the literature DA sold at a buck or two a brochure. Much of it was clear and simple advice that dovetails with the guidance I'm giving in this book. Put pen to paper. Write everything down. Have a plan. Keep meticulous records. Don't hide from your creditors. Seek help from experts. Stay financially honest. This is all excellent advice, because these habits create transparency. That leads to financial accountability and stability, which removes the mystery from money.

Fear and anxiety around money are usually the result of ignorance, of not knowing how much money you actually have, let alone where it is. Believe me, this is not a "rich people" problem. This is *not* the problem of having so much money you don't know where it is. In fact, wealthy people often know exactly what they're worth, right down to the last dollar in their wallet. They usually got rich because of meticulous money habits.

Financial ignorance is a problem that many people face, not just folks in DA. Many people are lazy when it comes to money matters, letting the banks keep their financial records; rarely, if ever, balancing their own checkbooks; or reconciling their accounts themselves. These are bad financial practices. They are what lead to the sense of powerlessness discussed in the rooms of DA. Of course, you're powerless over things about which you remain willfully ignorant.

Money Pledge

You may not need a place like Debtors Anonymous. I hope you don't. If you are like so many people out there and you are carrying some